

PULL-UP TEST A recruitment rally under way at Khasa, near Amritsar, Oct. 2018

AFP

CASE STUDY | BIHAR

ABHIRAM KUMAR, *20*; VIKAS KUMAR, *21*

Matriculate; Intermediate
Hulasganj, Jehanabad; Kudwa, Gaya

Prepared to Fight

Abhiram's father is a small farmer, whose income barely sustains his family of five, including three sons. Abhiram is keen to join as an Agniveer because of the job security and social prestige that comes with it. His only grouse is that the tenure should be at least 15 years and have pension benefits.

Vikas, on the other hand, wants to join the army because his father's half acre farmland holds no future for him, his only son. Agnipath's tenure is a matter of concern for him too. "Life is longer than four years," he says. He is therefore exploring options in the police force and the railways.

–Amitabh Srivastava



JITENDRA PUSHP

is devoted to the modernisation of forces. Average annual recruitment in the army was 60,000 before Covid struck and enrolments were suspended for two years. Consequently, vacancies for JCOs or junior commissioned officers and below climbed to 97,177. Under Agnipath, 40,000 people will be added this year, which will dwindle to 12,500 after four years, when 75 per cent of the first batch of Agniveers will be sent home.

The long-term plan is to trim the army's strength from the current 1.18 million to less than a million. "This will be done in a phased manner over the next decade," says a senior government official. "It is felt that if the army has to become a modern force driven by technology, it cannot be manpower-intensive." The financial burden of pensions, too, is expected to ease considerably. Pranay Kotasthane, deputy director, Takshashila Foundation, Bengaluru, estimates that letting 75 per cent of Agniveers go after four years alone will have a Net Present Value of Rs 34,500 crore on pension savings. But because pension outflows come much later, Kotasthane, in a recent column, said "these savings will accrue only after 15 years. But just as today's deficits are tomorrow's taxes, today's reform becomes tomorrow's savings."

If the central government has downplayed the job cuts in the armed forces and even denied it as an objective, it is because the overall constraints on the Indian economy have significantly shrunk the job opportunities in the past three years. Unemployment is a major issue and the government can ill afford to be seen eliminating existing government jobs. Already, some defence experts are asking why the armed forces are being picked for downsizing when the Modi government has just announced that it will fill up vacancies to the tune of 1 million in other central government departments in the next two years. As one expert said, "While it is okay to have a bloated babudom, we in the armed forces, who put our life on the line, are being subjected to a use-and-discard policy. It is like throwing a spanner into the what has been the strength of the army." Many feel the government should have been upfront about the need for